



Not clear enough: While Dunne's reasoning behind skipping trials was sound in principle, players were often left confused about where they stood in terms of selection. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

conference call, Dunne himself is out. Following a dismal performance by the Indian team at the World Olympic boxing qualifiers — the nine Indians in contention not only failed to win an Olympic quota but were eliminated in the very first round (except for one, Nishant Dev) — Dunne tendered his resignation to the Boxing Federation of India. His resignation was accepted, followed by the dismissal of Dmitry Dmitruk, who was working as a foreign coach with the men's team.

As things stand, India has only four boxers who have qualified for the Paris Olympics — all of them women. Although more boxers will be expected to qualify at the second World qualifiers in May, it is uncertain whether they will equal the number who booked their tickets to the Tokyo Games — nine.

According to one line of thinking, India's results, although disappointing, were on expected lines. While Dunne had produced impressive results as High-Performance Director of Ireland — they had won a gold and a bronze

in Tokyo after drawing a blank at the previous games in Rio — some argued that the same template might not fit in the Indian context.

A coach from the camp who didn't want to be named said, "It made no sense to limit the number of boxers in the camps. It might make sense when you don't have that many boxers. But India's biggest advantage has always been that we have a [significant] number of boxers. Within the 51kg category [itself], we have a tall boxer, a shorter one, someone who is technical, and someone who is a pressure fighter. That way, every boxer gets to spar with very different kinds of opponents. When you include just a few boxers, those in the camp don't get the same kind of practice."

Changed training patterns

According to another coach, Dunne had also introduced shorter, sharper training sessions once a day, in contrast to the twice-a-day workouts

that boxers had become used to. "This was something that didn't suit a lot of our boxers. Every boxer in the national camp has been boxing for at least a decade or more. You can see the result of the lower physical volume at the Olympic qualifiers," says another coach.

"Your technique will always be strong in the first round of a bout, but in the second and third, it is your physical conditioning that plays a key role. If you have so many Indians losing in the first round itself, it's clear that their physical conditioning wasn't at the level it should have been," says a coach.

Where Dunne found himself at the crossroads of most in Indian boxing though was in his insistence on doing away with selection trials. Dunne had once explained that by conducting trials, the coaches and selection panel were shirking their responsibility. He had added that boxers were focussing on the trials and then finding it hard

« Instead of trials, Dunne wanted to pick players based on consistency in training, discipline and sparring »»